

BATON CHARGE
The police take back the streets in Jodhpur, May 3; CM Gehlot at a press briefing

Jodhpur, like most other erstwhile princely states in Rajasthan, has a history of secular feudalism and has maintained communal peace for ages. Gehlot has represented Jodhpur in Parliament five times and is a five-time MLA from its urban assembly constituency, Sardarpura. His son Vaibhav contested but lost the general election from Jodhpur in 2019 and is likely to contest again as the CM's heir in 2024. So officers at the helm are handpicked for Jodhpur. Yet they could not sense the fallout of an unusual clash at midnight over hoisting of saffron flags versus green Muslim League ones at a crossing of Jalori Gate. It was brought under control but next morning, returning from Eid *namaaz*, a section of a mob turned violent. Things have not normalised even after a week. The Jodhpur riots were followed by an altercation in Bhilwara a day later. On May 11, communal tensions forced authorities to suspend internet there following reports that Hindu groups had given a bandh call for May 12.

Gehlot now has a big challenge on his hands. He can't be seen as appeasing Muslims for it will cost him the votes of Hindus. Muslims also make up just nine per cent of the population and there are very few seats where their vote is decisive. In the current assembly, there are just seven Muslim MLAs, all from the Congress, in a house of 200. Yet, Gehlot has a handicap—the liberal, Left-leaning advisors of the Gandhis who like to project a secular narrative and whose support Gehlot needs to remain afloat given that his main rival, Sachin Pilot, still has an inside line to the high command.

In both Karauli and Jodhpur, many Hindus claim the violence was brought to the actual point of precipitation by Muslims, which the government justifies in unofficial briefings as their natural reaction to instigation by Hindu right-wingers. Images old and new of Muslims lining up the roads offering *namaaz* with dozens of loudspeakers blaring from atop mosques in the walled city went viral on social media last week with the opposition BJP using it as 'evidence' of Gehlot's Muslim appeasement.

Gehlot was still smarting from the bad publicity after Karauli when violence broke out in his hometown Jodhpur on May 3

The CM is also fighting hard to take control of the media narrative. Gehlot claims that in Karauli the clashes barely lasted an hour and points to how his government has succeeded in curbing the incidents without any loss of lives. "These are not even riots," he claims while raking up the Delhi riots of 2020 and 2022 when the Union government-controlled Delhi Police "let parts of the national capital burn". He has rejected calls for a CBI investigation and has set up a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the violence.

Meanwhile, the CM's other woes continue. BJP MP Kirodi Lal Meena says the Enforcement Directorate has registered a case in the paper leak incident in the teachers' recruitment exam held last year. Sources say the state BJP is hopeful that the central agency's targeting of Congress ministers, leaders, officers and contractors will put the squeeze on the money flow to the party, especially with the Gujarat election at hand. The saffron party will also gain a moral victory if it forces Gehlot to sack Joshi. They have been unsuccessful in the recent past in the case of another MLA's son (again accused of rape).

Gehlot is in choppy waters, reminiscent of the last part of his second term which ended in 2013. Then, too, there was a major communal clash in Bharatpur district (2011), a minister was accused in a rape case, and the worst—the murder of Bhanwari Devi, an auxiliary nurse and alleged consort of then minister Mahipal Maderna and MLA Malkhan S. Bishnoi. "Rohit Joshi threatened me with the same fate as Bhanwari Devi," alleges the complainant in the current Rohit Joshi case, reminding people of Gehlot's bad run from a decade ago. Can the veteran CM ride this storm, emerge a winner by 2023-end? ■